

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

THE CARE GOVERNANCE DEFICIT:

Transforming Social Policy into Auditable Care Metrics in Low- and Middle-Income Countries

Across much of the developing world, social protection systems are entering a period of unprecedented strain. Population ageing is accelerating, urban migration continues to separate families, traditional care networks are weakening, and public institutions remain underprepared. The result is an expanding governance vacuum affecting millions of older persons and other vulnerable populations.

Historically, governments relied heavily on informal family structures to deliver care. This arrangement functioned as a de facto welfare system requiring little direct state investment. Today, demographic realities have fundamentally altered that equation. Increased life expectancy, labour migration, declining household sizes, economic pressures, and rising dependency ratios have exposed the limitations of a care model built almost entirely upon unpaid family labour.

The consequence is what this work defines as the Care Governance Deficit—a systemic condition in which institutions lack the mechanisms necessary to:

- Measure dignity-centred care outcomes;
- Verify service quality and institutional accountability;
- Monitor caregiver burden and resilience;
- Detect abuse, neglect, and social isolation;
- Allocate resources efficiently and equitably;
- Generate actionable, real-time policy intelligence.

In the absence of measurable indicators, human dignity remains an aspirational principle rather than an operational governance objective. What cannot be measured cannot be effectively governed.

To address this structural deficit, this book introduces the Care Governance Architecture (CGA)—an integrated framework that transforms social protection from a reactive, charity-driven model into an evidence-based system of measurable accountability.

At the centre of the architecture is the Geriatric Dignity Index (GDI), a multidimensional composite metric designed to evaluate care quality across five core dimensions:

Structural Autonomy;

Preserved Voice and Agency;

Psychosocial Legacy;

Protection and Safety;

Communitarian Participation.

Together, these dimensions translate abstract human rights principles into measurable administrative indicators capable of informing budgeting decisions, institutional audits, programme evaluations, and social policy reforms.

Beyond older adult care, this book proposes a scalable ecosystem of complementary indices, including:

- The Developmental Agency Index (DAI) for educational safeguarding and anti-bullying systems;
- The Disability Inclusion Index (DII) for accessibility and inclusion governance;
- The Caregiver Resilience Index (CRI) for workforce sustainability;
- The Community Protection Index (CPI) for vulnerable and displacement-affected populations.

Collectively, these frameworks constitute a next-generation Care Governance Architecture (CGA) capable of generating real-time policy intelligence through digital dashboards, mobile data collection, predictive analytics, and standardized field instruments.

The framework is specifically designed for application within low-resource settings and can support:

- National and sub-national governments;
- Ministries of Health, Social Welfare, and Education;
- Multilateral development banks and donor agencies;
- UNICEF and child protection institutions;
- Non-governmental organizations and humanitarian actors;
- Universities and research centres;
- Community-based care providers and social enterprises.

The central argument of this book is simple but transformative:

Human dignity should no longer exist merely as a moral aspiration or legal declaration. It must become an auditable governance asset—one that can be measured, verified, financed, monitored, and defended through evidence-based public policy.

The future of social protection will not be defined by goodwill alone. It will be determined by the capacity of institutions to convert compassion into systems, rights into metrics, and care into measurable outcomes.

The Care Governance Deficit therefore presents not merely a critique of existing welfare systems, but a practical blueprint for the next generation of social governance in Low- and Middle-Income Countries (LMICs)—a transition from charity to accountability, from assumptions to evidence, and from fragmented interventions to measurable, dignity-centred governance.

Keywords: Care Governance, Geriatric Dignity Index (GDI), Developmental Agency Index (DAI), Social Protection, Ageing Policy, Public Administration, Governance Metrics, Human Dignity, GovTech, Social Innovation, Low- and Middle-Income Countries (LMICs), CareBridge'07 Dynamic Global Ltd.